NAVIGATING GEOPOLITICAL SHIFTS

THE RUSSIA RUSH HOUR



DENIS ALIPOV
Russian ambassador to India

> **We can do without any peace negotiations with Ukraine. We are winning this war**
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> **The USSR collapsed, but NATO remains and declares Russia an enemy. How do we regard that?**
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> **India has always called for a peaceful resolution, and we value that very much**

Russia appreciates New Delhi's diplomatic balance during its ongoing conflict with Ukraine, said Russian ambassador to India Denis Alipov at the India Today Conclave 2025. While clarifying that Russia does not seek New Delhi's mediation, he commended India's consistent advocacy for peace. Speaking at the session titled 'Navigating Geopolitical Shifts', moderated by India Today Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa, Alipov drew a "red line" on Ukraine's NATO membership, declaring, "We need to have a Ukraine that does not pose a danger to us." He emphasised Russia's claims over Crimea, dismissed Ukraine president Zelensky's legitimacy and blamed the West for prolonging the conflict. Alipov stated that Russia has secured its strategic objectives in Ukraine and is not in a rush for talks. While Moscow is open to negotiations and even tripartite talks, Alipov accused Ukraine and its western backers of obstructing chances for peace.

On the second Trump administration, the Russian envoy said, "The approach of the current US administration, in comparison to its predecessors, is showing the right signs to stop the conflict in Europe." Alipov blamed NATO's expansion for fuelling the crisis. He added that since Ukraine's war effort was dependent on "NATO and other western backers", the conflict would have ended if this support had not been there.

Alipov urged India to expand economic ties with Russia despite western discouragement. He spoke about Moscow's recent offer to co-produce the fifth-generation Su-57 fighter jets—"a very lucrative deal for India". On Russia's position vis-a-vis the changing dynamics in India-China relations, Alipov said, "We are in favour of...building confidence between India and China. We don't want to take sides." ■

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **Ukraine's NATO membership is a red line—Russia will not negotiate on this issue. Moscow blames NATO for prolonging the war**
- **Russia is prepared to sit in a trilateral format for peace talks, though Moscow does not regard Zelensky as a legitimate president**

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**